

The Architecture of Factional Realignment: An Exhaustive Investigation into the Corporate, Advisory, and Lobbying Networks of Wes Streeting and Andy Burnham

1. Introduction: The Constitutional Crisis and the Shadow State of Modern Political Operations

The sudden resignation of Wes Streeting from his position as Secretary of State for Health and Social Care in May 2026 precipitated one of the most profound constitutional and political crises for the Labour Party since its return to power in July 2024. Arriving in the immediate wake of catastrophic local, Scottish, and Welsh election results—which saw the Labour Party lose approximately 1,500 council seats while facing a surging electoral threat from the populist right-wing Reform UK party—Streeting's departure was widely interpreted not merely as an administrative resignation, but as the initiation of a highly coordinated factional insurgency. His resignation letter, characterized by its devastating critique of Prime Minister Keir Starmer as a leader operating within a "vacuum" devoid of vision, served to fatally undermine the incumbent administration's authority and fracture the cabinet.

However, the resignation itself was merely the visible vanguard maneuver of a much broader, systemic realignment within the United Kingdom's ruling party. The crisis rapidly exposed a sophisticated, highly transactional alliance between Wes Streeting, the standard-bearer for the Blairite, pro-market right of the party, and Andy Burnham, the Mayor of Greater Manchester and the ascendant figurehead for Labour's soft-left. Operating in tandem, these two figures leveraged a complex, multi-layered network of political advisors, opaque corporate donors, influential think tanks, and crisis management firms to orchestrate the destabilization of the Starmer premiership and structure an intricate succession plan.

To comprehend the mechanics of this political detonation, it is imperative to move beyond the parliamentary frontline and examine the shadow state of modern political operations. The political viability of both Streeting and Burnham is overwhelmingly underwritten by distinct ecosystems of capital and strategy. For Streeting, this architecture is dominated by interests tied to private healthcare equity, global public relations firms, and corporate outsourcing. For Burnham, the infrastructure relies on regional mayoral networks, progressive think tanks, and a carefully cultivated coalition of soft-left parliamentarians.

Crucially, the entities bridging these two politicians are stained by profound and unprecedented institutional scandals. From illegal state surveillance operations and covert smear campaigns against journalists, to betting fraud and deep associations with disgraced international financiers, the advisory and corporate network facilitating the Streeting-Burnham axis reveals a culture of aggressive factionalism and democratic opacity. This exhaustive report provides a granular analysis of the specific advisors, core campaign teams, and corporate entities

associated with both men. Furthermore, it rigorously outlines their associations with other prominent politicians, and dissects the severe scandals embedded within their operations that directly intersect with the United Kingdom's governing apparatus.

2. The Financial Architecture of Wes Streeting: Capital, Consultancy, and the Private Healthcare Nexus

Wes Streeting's political ascent has been characterized by a formidable capacity to attract significant financial backing from corporate entities, hedge funds, and private wealth managers. This financial architecture is not merely incidental to his political success; it is directly correlated with his ideological positioning and his policy directives during his tenure at the Department of Health and Social Care (DHSC). A rigorous examination of his donor base reveals an overwhelming reliance on capital derived from the private healthcare sector, recruitment outsourcing, and corporate lobbying.

2.1 Peter Hearn, MPM Connect, and the OPD Group

The most significant and consistent financial benefactor of Wes Streeting's political operation is Peter Hearn. Hearn is a highly successful recruitment executive whose corporate portfolio specializes in senior NHS executive recruitment and assisting private sector providers in recruiting healthcare professionals. Hearn operates his political philanthropy primarily through a complex web of corporate vehicles, most notably MPM Connect Ltd and OPD Group Ltd. MPM Connect emerged in 2023 as a focal point of intense journalistic and parliamentary scrutiny due to its status as one of Westminster's largest, yet most opaque, political donors. Despite funneling hundreds of thousands of pounds into the political offices of senior Labour MPs, MPM Connect possessed no active website, demonstrated no clear public-facing business operations, and was registered to an accountant's office where the staff claimed no knowledge of the firm's existence. The company's accounts failed to disclose the origins of its funding or the precise nature of its investments.

Through MPM Connect, Hearn aggressively financed the moderate, right-leaning wing of the Labour Party. Streeting received substantial funding from the firm, accepting £35,475 in 2023 to cover constituency office staffing costs, paid in installments that periodically increased in value. However, Streeting was not the sole beneficiary. MPM Connect's financial influence extended to other prominent figures within the Shadow Cabinet. Yvette Cooper, who later became Home Secretary, received over £73,000 across four separate donations from the firm. Dan Jarvis, another prominent Labour moderate and former South Yorkshire Mayor, received £25,000. When confronted by media investigations led by Sky News, Streeting, Cooper, and Jarvis released remarkably similar statements defending the donations, characterizing MPM Connect simply as an "investment company in the employment sector" and insisting all Electoral Commission rules had been followed.

As public scrutiny regarding the shadowy nature of MPM Connect intensified, Hearn's funding mechanism for Streeting smoothly transitioned to his parent company, the OPD Group Ltd. MPM Connect reportedly owns up to half of the shares of the OPD Group, where Hearn serves on the board. In early 2026, Streeting registered a massive £55,000 donation from the OPD Group, specifically scheduled to cover staffing costs in his constituency office throughout the

year. In total, Hearn's corporate entities—combined with £40,000 in personal donations made between 2017 and 2019—have supplied Streeting's political operation with nearly £200,000. The systemic implications of this funding stream are profound. Throughout his nearly 700-day tenure as Health Secretary, Streeting aggressively pursued policies designed to integrate private sector capacity into the National Health Service, routinely arguing that utilizing private healthcare to clear NHS backlogs was a pragmatic necessity rather than an ideological betrayal. The empirical data reveals that over 60% of Streeting's total political donations since entering Parliament in 2015—amounting to an estimated £372,000—originated from individuals and corporate entities with direct commercial links to private healthcare. This represents a stark and undeniable alignment between his ministerial policy directives and the commercial interests of his primary financial backers.

2.2 Hedge Funds, Private Equity, and Global Wealth

Streeting's operation is additionally subsidized by immense global private wealth, particularly from the financial sector. He received £95,000 from John Armitage, a prominent hedge fund manager and the head of the UK investment firm Egerton Capital. Armitage's financial interests are highly relevant to the healthcare sector; he reportedly holds hundreds of millions of dollars in stock in UnitedHealth, the largest private health insurance provider in the United States. Like Hearn's contributions, Armitage's donations were frequently logged as being directed toward Streeting's "staffing costs".

Furthermore, Streeting accepted £13,500 from Sir Trevor Chinn, a veteran corporate lobbyist and a senior advisor to CVC Capital Partners. CVC Capital is a behemoth within the private equity landscape, holding vast investments in private health and social care companies across the United Kingdom, Europe, and Asia. A £5,000 donation specifically designated to support Streeting's campaigning in Ilford North in early 2025 highlights the targeted nature of this capital injection.

This network of private healthcare wealth is further augmented by a £5,000 donation from Red Capital Ltd. This corporate entity is controlled by Lord Jonathan Mendelsohn, a sitting director at the Europa Healthcare Group, a private healthcare provider. The cumulative effect of these donations generated significant friction within the Labour Party, with campaign groups like EveryDoctor calculating that Streeting received £224,575 from private healthcare-linked donors between 2023 and 2025 alone.

2.3 The Advisory Network: New Labour Veterans and Think Tanks

To translate this financial capital into effective political strategy, Streeting relies on an advisory network deeply embedded in the traditional Westminster apparatus and the legacy of the New Labour era. His partner, Joe Dancey, is an experienced communications and public affairs adviser who unsuccessfully ran as the Labour parliamentary candidate for Stockton West in 2024, providing Streeting with immediate, high-level political counsel regarding media grid management.

Within the machinery of government, Streeting sought to bypass traditional civil service caution by appointing specialized political operators. In October 2025, he appointed Matthew Hood OBE as a direct senior ministerial adviser to the Department of Health and Social Care. Hood's specific mandate was to work with the department's delivery unit to ensure that the government's priorities were executed during Streeting's period of radical NHS reform. Ideologically and strategically, Streeting was heavily influenced by former Blairite Health

Secretary Alan Milburn. Acting as a government adviser, Milburn reportedly counseled Streeting on the mechanics of institutional survival, famously advising him to "buy time" by initiating long-term structural reviews. This advice directly culminated in Streeting's launch of the 10-Year Health Plan and the "Change NHS" initiative.

Furthermore, Streeting's operations have been facilitated by the Tony Blair Institute for Global Change (TBI). The TBI covered the costs for Streeting, alongside fellow Cabinet Minister Peter Kyle, to attend a high-level conference in Brussels in 2023. Given that the TBI has openly advocated for the NHS to offer paid services for patients and recommended replacing local GPs with AI chatbots, the institutional linkage between Streeting's political rise and the Blairite privatization agenda is unequivocal.

Donor / Corporate Entity	Key Figure / Executive	Primary Sector Focus	Total Estimated Funding to Streeting	Associated Political Beneficiaries
MPM Connect / OPD Group	Peter Hearn	NHS / Private Healthcare Recruitment	~£200,000	Yvette Cooper, Dan Jarvis
Egerton Capital	John Armitage	US Healthcare Hedge Funds (UnitedHealth)	£95,000	N/A
PLMR	Kevin Craig	Corporate Lobbying / PR / Crisis Management	£52,000	Rachel Reeves, Angela Rayner, David Lammy
CVC Capital Partners	Sir Trevor Chinn	Private Equity / Global Healthcare	£13,500	N/A
Red Capital Ltd	Lord Jonathan Mendelsohn	Europa Healthcare Group	£5,000	N/A

3. The PLMR Nexus: Kevin Craig, Corporate Lobbying, and Betting Scandals

A central, highly active node in the financial and advisory network surrounding the Labour Party's right wing—and Wes Streeting in particular—is Kevin Craig, the founder and Chief Executive Officer of the lobbying and public relations firm Political Lobbying and Media Relations (PLMR). Craig's career represents the seamless integration of corporate lobbying, philanthropic posturing, and aggressive internal party politics.

3.1 PLMR's Influence Across the Labour Frontbench

Craig has been a prolific and strategic donor to Streeting. He provided an initial £13,000 to Streeting's office and subsequently committed an additional £39,000 toward staffing costs in 2024, scheduled in £13,000 installments. This funding is highly controversial given the nature of PLMR's client base. PLMR explicitly markets itself as a leading health and social care specialist communications agency, providing crisis management and stakeholder engagement services. Crucially, PLMR advises and represents firms that provide temporary staffing and agency personnel to the NHS, such as the recruitment giant Adecco, as well as medical device manufacturers and major care home providers like HC-One. At a time when the NHS was

spending a record £4.6 billion on agency personnel, the Health Secretary accepting nearly £52,000 from the chief executive of a lobbying firm representing those exact agencies represents a profound conflict of interest.

Craig's financial influence is not limited to Streeting; it permeates the highest echelons of the Labour cabinet. He purchased a website domain for Chancellor Rachel Reeves valued at £1,934. Furthermore, PLMR is notorious within Westminster for sponsoring high-profile networking events and receptions that grant corporate clients direct, privileged access to senior Labour politicians. Deputy Prime Minister Angela Rayner, Business Secretary Jonathan Reynolds, and Foreign Secretary David Lammy have all made appearances at events sponsored by PLMR and similar lobbying firms, solidifying the agency's political capital across multiple factions.

3.2 The Anti-Labour Lobbying Scandal (VAT on Private Schools)

The transactional nature of Craig's relationship with the Labour Party was brutally exposed in the lead-up to the 2024 general election. Craig had donated £100,000 directly to the Labour Party, a massive financial injection that preceded his unopposed selection as the Labour parliamentary candidate for Central Suffolk and North Ipswich.

However, journalistic investigations revealed a staggering contradiction. While running as a Labour candidate, Craig's firm, PLMR, was actively contracted by the Independent Schools Council (ISC). The ISC is the powerful industry trade body for private schools, and it was engaged in a fierce, multi-million-pound media and governmental lobbying campaign to defeat Keir Starmer's flagship domestic policy: charging VAT on private school fees to fund the recruitment of 6,500 new state school teachers.

PLMR was actively generating negative press exposure and lobbying Whitehall departments to subvert a core Labour manifesto pledge, warning of an "exodus" of private school pupils. When confronted, Craig attempted to compartmentalize the issue, claiming that his managing director handled the education clients and asserting his personal belief in Labour's policy. Nevertheless, the spectacle of a Labour candidate running a firm actively lobbying against the party leader's primary revenue-raising policy underscored the deep, often contradictory entanglements between the corporate lobbying sector and the modern Labour Party.

3.3 The Gambling Commission Betting Fraud

Craig's political career imploded entirely due to an astonishing personal scandal. In June 2024, at the height of the general election campaign, the Labour Party was forced to immediately suspend Craig as a candidate. He had been contacted by the Gambling Commission, which launched a formal investigation into his conduct.

It emerged that Craig had placed a financial bet against himself, gambling that he would lose the election in his own constituency of Central Suffolk and North Ipswich. This extraordinary act of political sabotage and potential betting fraud forced the Labour Party to withdraw all support for him, leaving them without a viable candidate in the seat. Following his suspension, Streeting's spokesperson announced that they would return the £13,000 Craig had provided for staffing costs. However, the reputational damage had been inflicted, permanently linking Streeting's political operation to a disgraced corporate lobbyist.

Interestingly, while Craig is firmly associated with the right of the party, PLMR as an entity has actively mapped and engaged with the broader factional realignment. Craig himself commented publicly on the shifting power dynamics within the party, noting that a successful reshuffle and

deputy leadership election presented opportunities for new alliances. PLMR's interactive "Labour Tribes" maps have recently highlighted Andy Burnham's "Mainstream" group as a critical new power center, indicating the lobbying industry's pragmatic pivot toward the Greater Manchester Mayor as Starmer's authority weakened.

4. The Burnham Operation: Soft-Left Infrastructure and Regional Strategy

In stark contrast to Wes Streeting's reliance on Westminster-based corporate lobbyists and private equity wealth, Andy Burnham's political operation is rooted in regional devolution, progressive think tanks, and a carefully cultivated outsider persona. Dubbed the "King of the North" following his highly publicized clash with the Conservative government over pandemic tier restrictions in October 2020, Burnham has utilized his position as Mayor of Greater Manchester to build an alternative power base completely independent of Keir Starmer's centralized control.

4.1 The Core Team: Kevin Lee and the Mayoral Apparatus

Burnham's immediate political operation is notoriously lean. Unlike his rivals in London who rely on sprawling networks of Special Advisers, the Greater Manchester Mayor is entitled to only one full-time paid political adviser. This role is filled by Kevin Lee, the Director of the GMCA Mayor's Office.

Lee is a veteran political operative who serves as the bureaucratic and strategic spine of the Burnham project. His relationship with Burnham dates back decades; Lee served as a special adviser to former Culture Secretary Chris Smith from 1998 to 2001, overlapping with the early New Labour era. Crucially, Lee served as the campaign manager for Andy Burnham's unsuccessful 2015 Labour leadership bid against Jeremy Corbyn, and subsequently managed Burnham's Westminster office.

Operating firmly behind the scenes, Lee orchestrates Burnham's regional strategy, maintaining his authentic, slightly rebellious public persona while navigating the complex, multi-billion-pound budgets of the Combined Authority. This tight-knit operation is supplemented by historical allies from previous campaigns, including Philip Ball (a former political adviser) and Philippa Menzies (head of operations and events), alongside personal support from his wife, Marie-France van Heel.

While Burnham currently relies on the GMCA infrastructure, his historical donor base during his 2015 leadership run reveals an ability to attract significant capital when operating on a national level. He received tens of thousands of pounds from wealthy individuals including Dr. Gabriel Scally (£20,000), Graham Nigel Cole (£27,000 across multiple donations), Imtiaz Shah (£15,000), and Michael Sternberg.

4.2 Ideological Advisors: Compass, Neal Lawson, and the Policy Ecosystem

Burnham's intellectual and policy platform—often summarized as "Manchesterism," advocating for proportional representation, the abolition of the House of Lords, and wealth taxes—is deeply influenced by a network of progressive think tanks. Influential voices advising "Team Andy"

include Mathew Lawrence, the director of the left-wing think tank Common Wealth, Zoë Billingham of IPPR North, and Andrew Carter, CEO of Centre for Cities.

However, the most critical ideological architect behind Burnham's resurgence is Neal Lawson, the director of the centre-left pressure group Compass. Lawson, a former New Labour adviser who shifted leftward, is a fierce advocate for political pluralism and cross-party alliances. Lawson and Burnham share a long-standing personal relationship, having played together for the Labour football team "Demon Eyes". Lawson provides the strategic framework for Burnham's appeal, arguing that Burnham is uniquely positioned to attract voters from both the Green Party and Reform UK—a critical metric for electoral success in a fragmented political landscape.

4.3 The Compass Controversy and the Factional War

Lawson's association with Burnham places him directly in the crosshairs of Keir Starmer's disciplinary apparatus. In June 2023, Lawson received an expulsion notice from the Labour Party, an act that shocked seasoned observers. The official pretext for the expulsion threat was a tweet from May 2021 in which Lawson retweeted Liberal Democrat MP Layla Moran, endorsing an electoral pact where voters would back Green candidates in local elections to defeat Conservatives, characterizing it as "grownup progressive politics".

The Labour leadership—driven by operatives like Morgan McSweeney—utilized this minor infraction to launch a 17-month probe into Lawson, claiming he had supported an organization "inimical" to Labour's aims. Lawson fiercely contested the charges, ultimately being found "not guilty," but the ordeal exposed the intense paranoia and authoritarian "control freakery" dominating Starmer's internal party management. Lawson argued that the party had been captured by a "clique who see only true believers or sworn enemies," behaving like "playground bullies". This factional warfare solidified Compass's opposition to Starmer and accelerated their efforts to construct an alternative power base around Burnham.

4.4 Mainstream Labour: The Soft-Left Insurgency

In direct response to Starmer's perceived rightward drift and authoritarian internal culture, Neal Lawson and Compass, in collaboration with the soft-left group Open Labour, co-founded a new political network in late 2025: "Mainstream Labour". Mainstream was explicitly designed to reverse the party's trajectory and provide a home for Labour's "radical realists".

The network boasts a highly influential interim council, including Kerry Postlewhite, Mark Cooke, Alex Sobel, Ruth Lister, Sue Goss, Lauren Davison, and Lawson himself. Mainstream quickly garnered the backing of a broad coalition of parliamentarians across the soft-left and traditional left, including Clive Efford (chair of the Tribune group of MPs), former cabinet ministers John Denham and Clare Short, Jon Cruddas, Clive Lewis, Dawn Butler, Paula Barker, Rachael Maskell, and Momentum founder Jon Lansman.

At the absolute center of this new political vehicle is Andy Burnham. Mainstream is widely recognized by Westminster analysts as the institutional vehicle engineered to propel Burnham back into Parliament and ultimately to Number 10 Downing Street. Burnham utilized the launch of Mainstream to publicly attack Starmer's disciplinary culture, stating, "We've got to get beyond this culture where everything's a threat... You don't win through a factional approach". By late 2025, Mainstream was actively campaigning for Burnham to be allowed to seek selection for upcoming by-elections, setting the stage for the dramatic events of May 2026.

5. The Intelligence State and Factional Warfare: The APCO Worldwide Scandal

To fully understand the mechanics of the May 2026 crisis, one must examine the institutional scandals that discredited Starmer's core team and provided the specific parliamentary opening for Andy Burnham. The most explosive domestic scandal intersecting with this network involves the think tank Labour Together, the PR consultancy APCO Worldwide, and Josh Simons.

5.1 Labour Together and the Dark Money Fine

Labour Together (later rebranded as Think Labour) was established as a vehicle to bridge party factions but rapidly evolved under the direction of Morgan McSweeney into the primary strategic engine dedicated to eradicating the Corbynite left and installing Keir Starmer as leader. However, the organization's rise was fueled by illicit financial practices. Between 2017 and 2020, Labour Together failed to declare £730,000 in political donations from millionaire venture capitalists and businessmen, leading to an Electoral Commission investigation where the group was fined and found guilty of over 20 separate breaches of electoral law. When McSweeney departed to become Starmer's all-powerful Chief of Staff in Downing Street, the directorship of Labour Together was handed to Josh Simons. Simons, a former research scientist at Meta and uniquely, a former policy adviser in Jeremy Corbyn's office who subsequently defected to the party's right wing, transformed the think tank into a highly aggressive factional instrument.

5.2 Operation Cannon: Smears and State Surveillance

In November 2023, investigative journalists from *The Sunday Times*—specifically Gabriel Pogrund and Paul Holden—began publishing rigorous exposés regarding Labour Together's dark money network and its failure to declare funding. Rather than addressing the legal breaches transparently, Josh Simons authorized a staggering abuse of power. Labour Together commissioned the global public affairs agency APCO Worldwide, paying them £36,000 to conduct a covert investigation into the journalists themselves.

This project, codenamed "Operation Cannon," resulted in a 58-page dossier authored by Tom Harper, a senior APCO director and former *Sunday Times* journalist. The report was an exercise in aggressive defamation. Utilizing "discreet human source enquiries," Harper fabricated a narrative claiming, without a shred of evidence, that the journalists' reporting was based on data hacked from the Electoral Commission by the Russian state.

Furthermore, the APCO report engaged in highly personal, prejudiced attacks. It specifically targeted Gabriel Pogrund, referencing his Jewish background and making baseless allegations regarding his faith, his upbringing, and his personal and professional relationships in a clear attempt at character assassination. The dossier also circulated highly personal information regarding Paul Holden.

The scandal escalated beyond corporate smearing when Simons attempted to weaponize the British intelligence apparatus. Simons forwarded a condensed version of the "Operation Cannon" dossier to GCHQ's National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC). In these emails, Simons explicitly told state intelligence officials that the material published by the journalists was linked to "people known to be operating in a pro-Kremlin propaganda network with links to Russian

intelligence". This was a deliberate attempt to trigger a state security investigation into domestic journalists engaged in public interest reporting.

5.3 The Cover-Up and the Makerfield Transaction

When the depth of "Operation Cannon" was exposed by the media in early 2026, the political fallout was catastrophic. The National Union of Journalists (NUJ) condemned the actions as an affront to press freedom and democracy. Veteran Labour backbencher John McDonnell demanded an independent inquiry, while Conservative Party Chair Kevin Hollinrake called for immediate investigations into the involvement of serving cabinet ministers. It was further reported that APCO's Tom Harper had instructed a freelance contractor involved in the project to destroy evidence of its actions.

Simons, who had subsequently been elected as the MP for Makerfield in 2024 and appointed as a Parliamentary Under-Secretary of State for Digital Government, found his position untenable. Prime Minister Keir Starmer, claiming he "didn't know anything about" the operation, referred Simons to the independent adviser on ministerial standards, Sir Laurie Magnus. On February 28, 2026, Simons was forced to resign his ministerial positions in disgrace.

It is here that the APCO scandal directly intersects with the ascension of Andy Burnham. Disgraced, stripped of his ministerial portfolio, and facing hostility from Starmer loyalists, Simons sought a mechanism for political rehabilitation outside of Downing Street's control. On May 14, 2026, Simons executed an astonishing maneuver: he abruptly resigned his seat in Makerfield entirely, explicitly stating he was stepping down to trigger a by-election to allow Andy Burnham a route back into Parliament. Simons framed this act of self-sacrifice as a necessary "shock to the Westminster system," declaring that Burnham was required to provide the "radical, courageous reform" that Starmer's government lacked.

The hypocrisy of the situation was glaring: a political operative who had utilized dark money and attempted to weaponize state intelligence against journalists to protect the Starmer project was now falling on his sword to crown the leader of the soft-left insurgency. This transactional pact provided Burnham with the essential constitutional prerequisite—a parliamentary seat—necessary to challenge for the leadership.

6. The Global Counsel Collapse and the Peter Mandelson Vetting Row

While the APCO scandal devastated the strategic core of Starmer's team, a parallel scandal involving Peter Mandelson and the lobbying firm Global Counsel inflicted fatal damage on the Prime Minister's personal authority, deeply implicating Wes Streeting's factional allies in the process.

6.1 The Fall of Global Counsel

Peter Mandelson, a towering architect of the New Labour era, co-founded the lobbying and strategic advisory firm Global Counsel alongside Benjamin Wegg-Prosser in 2010 following Labour's general election defeat. The firm rapidly became a powerhouse, securing highly lucrative contracts advising global technology and pharmaceutical conglomerates, including Palantir, TikTok, OpenAI, GSK, and Vodafone.

However, the firm was built on a fault line of profound reputational risk: Mandelson's historical,

highly publicized links to the convicted child sex offender, Jeffrey Epstein. When international scrutiny regarding these ties intensified in early 2026, Global Counsel suffered a catastrophic mass exodus of corporate clients unwilling to be associated with the escalating scandal. On February 20, 2026, Global Counsel went into administration and collapsed. Figures filed at Companies House revealed the firm owed £4.54 million to creditors, possessing only £2.7 million in assets for preferential creditors. Crucially, the firm collapsed owing HM Revenue and Customs (HMRC) a staggering £645,789 in unpaid taxes. The timing was disastrous; exactly three days after the firm went bust, Peter Mandelson was arrested and bailed by police following allegations that he had passed sensitive intelligence to Jeffrey Epstein during his tenure as Business Secretary.

6.2 The Vetting Crisis and Starmer's Authority

The collapse of Global Counsel and Mandelson's arrest ignited a massive constitutional crisis for Keir Starmer, who had recently appointed Mandelson as the United Kingdom's Ambassador to the United States. The controversy centered on the integrity of the security vetting process that cleared Mandelson for such a sensitive diplomatic posting.

Parliamentary committees exposed severe irregularities in the appointment. It was revealed that Morgan McSweeney—Starmer's Chief of Staff and the former head of Labour Together—had applied immense, inappropriate pressure on the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) to expedite Mandelson's security clearance, actively overriding concerns raised by UK Security Vetting (UKSV). Dr. Ian Collard, a top Foreign Office official, testified to feeling intense pressure for a "rapid outcome," while former FCDO permanent secretary Olly Robbins testified that "constant pressure" was applied by Downing Street to force the appointment through.

This testimony directly contradicted statements made by Keir Starmer during Prime Minister's Questions (PMQs). Starmer had categorically assured the House of Commons that no pressure had been put on the Foreign Office, prompting immediate accusations from across the political spectrum that the Prime Minister had misled Parliament. Independent MP Karl Turner, alongside Shadow Chancellor Mel Stride and Liberal Democrat Leader Ed Davey, demanded that Starmer face the privileges committee for his "at best, inaccurate and, at worst, misleading" statements. While Starmer narrowly avoided a formal privileges inquiry, his authority within the parliamentary party was shattered. He was perceived as having compromised national security to reward a disgraced factional ally, creating the exact political vulnerability that Wes Streeting and Andy Burnham would exploit in May.

6.3 Wes Streeting's Entanglement and the Palantir Connection

The toxicity of the Mandelson affair directly threatened Wes Streeting. Historically viewed as a close ally and ideological successor to Mandelson within the party's right wing, Streeting found himself caught in the fallout. To mitigate the damage, Streeting was forced into a desperate, preemptive damage-control operation in February 2026, publishing a tranche of private text messages and emails between himself and Mandelson to prove he had "nothing to hide" and to distance himself from the disgraced peer.

However, the disclosure backfired. The texts revealed an uncomfortable intimacy, with Streeting signing off messages with a kiss. More concerning, the correspondence revealed that in June 2025, Mandelson offered to connect Streeting with "lots of tech companies and people" during an upcoming visit to the United States.

This offer was highly significant given Mandelson's corporate interests. Global Counsel represented Palantir, a controversial US data analytics firm founded by Peter Thiel. Later that year, under Streeting's oversight at the DHSC, Palantir received a massive £240 million contract from the government, granted via direct award, to manage NHS data. Streeting had also attended the secretive Bilderberg meeting in Sweden the previous year alongside Palantir executives. Medical advocacy groups, including the Doctors' Association UK (DAUK), cited these texts to demand greater transparency from Streeting regarding his private communications with healthcare donors and corporate lobbyists, arguing that the Palantir contract represented the nexus of Mandelson's lobbying, Streeting's privatization agenda, and corporate profiteering within the NHS.

Corporate Entity / Think Tank	Key Operatives	Associated Politician	Primary Scandal / Controversy	Institutional Impact
Labour Together / APCO Worldwide	Josh Simons, Tom Harper, Morgan McSweeney	Andy Burnham (via Makerfield seat transfer), Keir Starmer	Operation Cannon: Smeared journalists investigating dark money; fabricated Russian intelligence links; attempted to weaponize GCHQ/NCSC.	Simons forced to resign as minister; subsequently vacated seat to facilitate Burnham's leadership bid.
Global Counsel	Peter Mandelson, Benjamin Wegg-Prosser	Wes Streeting (Allied faction), Keir Starmer	Epstein Links & Vetting Row: Mandelson arrested over Epstein intelligence sharing; firm collapsed owing HMRC £645k; Starmer accused of misleading Parliament.	Streeting forced to publish private texts regarding Palantir. Starmer's authority shattered.
PLMR	Kevin Craig	Wes Streeting	Betting Fraud & Anti-Labour Lobbying: Craig bet against his own electoral success; PLMR actively lobbied against Labour's VAT policy on private schools.	Craig suspended by Labour. Exposed Streeting's reliance on ideologically compromised corporate lobbyists.

7. The Synthesis: The Streeting-Burnham Collusion

and the May 2026 Crisis

The culmination of these disparate factional dynamics, financial pressures, and catastrophic institutional scandals materialized on May 14, 2026. Recognizing that Starmer's premiership was mortally wounded by the Mandelson vetting row and the APCO surveillance scandal, and armed with the pretext of disastrous local election results, Wes Streeting executed his resignation.

Streeting's departure was an exercise in calculated destabilization. By resigning and delivering a blistering critique of Starmer's competence, Streeting shattered the convention of collective cabinet responsibility and signaled to the parliamentary party that the Prime Minister was a terminal liability. However, Streeting faced an insurmountable logistical hurdle: he lacked the requisite parliamentary arithmetic (the backing of 81 Labour MPs) to trigger and win a leadership election unilaterally.

Simultaneously, Andy Burnham possessed overwhelming popularity among the electorate—boasting a net favorability rating of 24%, vastly outperforming Starmer—but lacked the constitutional prerequisite of a parliamentary seat.

7.1 The Tactical Alliance and the Makerfield By-Election

Recognizing their mutual limitations, the vanguards of the Labour right and the soft-left engaged in a tactical, highly transactional alliance. Think tanks like the Labour Growth Group (LGG)—headed by Chris Curtis and ideologically blending Starmerite concepts with "Yimbyism" and wealth taxes—had already begun circulating policy documents to both the Streeting and Burnham camps, creating backchannel intellectual bridges between the factions.

The alliance was operationalized on the exact day of Streeting's resignation. As Streeting absorbed the immediate institutional heat of cabinet treachery by acting as a stalking-horse candidate, Josh Simons executed his resignation in Makerfield. This meticulously timed sacrifice provided Burnham with the vehicle to re-enter Westminster.

Streeting subsequently cemented the pact by publicly endorsing Burnham's candidacy for the Makerfield by-election. Speaking just days after his resignation, Streeting declared that Labour needed "our best players on the pitch," explicitly stating that "Andy is the best chance of winning and that should override factional advantage or propping up one person". He pledged to campaign on the ground for Burnham, recognizing that facilitating the Mayor's return was essential to maintaining the momentum of the coup against Starmer.

7.2 The Fragility of the Axis

Despite the mechanical success of the Makerfield maneuver, the Streeting-Burnham alliance remains fundamentally fragile, built upon contradictory ideologies and volatile electoral realities. The fragility was immediately exposed during Streeting's formal leadership launch at a Progress think tank conference on May 16. Moving beyond domestic healthcare, Streeting aggressively pivoted toward foreign policy, declaring Brexit a "catastrophic mistake" and advocating for a "new special relationship" and eventual reentry into the European Union.

This pro-European posture directly sabotaged Burnham's immediate electoral imperatives in Makerfield. Located on the edge of Greater Manchester, Makerfield is a heavily pro-Brexit constituency where the populist, right-wing Reform UK party had surged, winning every single council ward in the local elections. Burnham required a narrative focused on regional pride,

economic populism, and cultural conservatism to defeat Nigel Farage's party. Streeting's loud prioritization of the "Brexit wars" threatened to alienate the exact demographic Burnham needed to capture, highlighting the inherent contradictions of pairing a London-centric Blairite with a Northern regionalist.

Furthermore, the pact generated intense hostility from Starmer loyalists and rival factions. Cabinet ministers like Lisa Nandy publicly dismissed the leadership speculation as "froth and nonsense," criticizing Streeting's EU policy as entirely disconnected from the electorate's desires. Meanwhile, figures within Burnham's own soft-left ecosystem, who had suffered under the disciplinary regimes of operatives like Morgan McSweeney and Josh Simons, viewed the alliance with Streeting—a man bankrolled by private healthcare equity and corporate lobbyists—with deep suspicion.

8. Conclusion

The political detonation orchestrated in May 2026 was the byproduct of a systemic realignment within the Labour Party, driven by the collapse of Keir Starmer's authority and the opportunistic convergence of historically opposed factions. Wes Streeting's resignation served as the catalyst, but the true mechanics of the crisis were facilitated by an opaque shadow state of corporate donors, lobbying firms, and progressive think tanks.

The evidentiary matrix clearly defines these networks. Streeting's political viability is fundamentally underwritten by millions of pounds from private healthcare executives like Peter Hearn and hedge fund managers like John Armitage, channeled through obscure corporate entities like MPM Connect. His aggressive privatization agenda within the NHS is inextricably linked to these financial imperatives, further facilitated by corporate lobbyists like Kevin Craig and the PLMR nexus. Conversely, Andy Burnham relies on a regional bureaucratic apparatus managed by Kevin Lee, and an intellectual architecture provided by Neal Lawson, Compass, and the Mainstream Labour network to project a populist, anti-Westminster aura.

However, the entities bridging these two politicians are hopelessly compromised by profound institutional scandals. Josh Simons and Labour Together's orchestration of "Operation Cannon"—a covert, illegal campaign to smear journalists and weaponize state intelligence to protect dark money—represents a severe abuse of democratic norms. That Simons utilized his subsequent disgrace to vacate his Makerfield seat and facilitate Burnham's ascent confirms that the soft-left's revival is actively reliant on the architects of Starmer's most authoritarian overreaches. Furthermore, the spectacular collapse of Peter Mandelson's Global Counsel amid the Jeffrey Epstein fallout, and the ensuing parliamentary crisis regarding Mandelson's security vetting, paralyzed the Starmer administration, creating the exact vacuum Streeting claimed to be protesting while exposing his own uncomfortable ties to Palantir and NHS data contracts. Ultimately, the Streeting-Burnham axis is a highly transactional marriage of convenience. United strictly by parliamentary arithmetic and a shared desire to terminate Keir Starmer's premiership, this alliance attempts an unnatural fusion of the privatization-friendly, corporate-backed Labour right with the regionalist, progressive soft-left. As global bond markets react violently to the political instability—driving government borrowing costs to a 28-year high in fear of a Burnham premiership—and Reform UK prepares to fiercely contest the Makerfield by-election, the constitutional integrity of the Labour Party remains critically endangered by the very operatives attempting to commandeer it.

Works cited

1. Pharmacy sector warns of 'more uncertainty' as Wes Streeting resigns as health secretary, <https://pharmaceutical-journal.com/article/news/pharmacy-sector-warns-of-more-uncertainty-as-wes-streeting-resigns-as-health-secretary>
2. Keir Starmer tries to consolidate power amid scandals - The Lion, <https://readlion.com/keir-starmer-tries-to-consolidate-power-amid-scandals/>
3. Britain's Starmer fights for his job as calls for his ouster grow after local election losses, <https://www.ksat.com/news/world/2026/05/10/britains-starmer-fights-for-his-job-as-calls-for-his-ouster-grow-after-local-election-losses/>
4. What Wes Streeting said in his resignation letter – and what he meant, <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/politics/wes-streeting-quits-keir-starmer-labour-b2976648.html>
5. Josh Simons - Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Josh_Simons
6. Pressure on UK PM Starmer ramps up as Burnham closer to challenge, <https://global.morningstar.com/en-gb/news/alliance-news/1778920066039971400/pressure-on-uk-pm-starmer-ramps-up-as-burnham-closer-to-challenge>
7. Pressure mounts on Starmer as Labour MP resigns, paving way for return of leadership rival Andy Burnham, <https://www.washingtonexaminer.com/news/world/4569064/pressure-starmer-labour-mp-resign-andy-burnham/>
8. Wes Streeting as Health Secretary: Privatisation, chaos, failure - Keep Our NHS Public, <https://keepournhspublic.com/wes-streeting-privatisation-chaos-failure/>
9. The House Opinion Article | Worker Bees: Inside The Burnham Operation - Politics Home, <https://www.politicshome.com/news/article/worker-bees-inside-burnham-operation>
10. How private health has invested in Wes Streeting | Good Law Project, <https://goodlawproject.org/how-private-health-has-invested-in-wes-streeting/>
11. Wes Streeting may well be Labour's angel of death - Socialist Worker, <https://socialistworker.co.uk/labour/wes-streeting-may-well-be-labours-angel-of-death/>
12. The Labour MPs raking it in as they slash benefits - Socialist Worker, <https://socialistworker.co.uk/labour/the-labour-mps-raking-it-in-as-they-slash-welfare/>
13. Wes Streeting Financial Disclosures - Parallel Parliament, <https://www.parallelparliament.co.uk/mp/wes-streeting/financial-disclosure>
14. Labour MPs defend accepting tens of thousands from little-known company - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2023/jan/10/labour-mps-defend-taking-donations-from-little-known-company>
15. Why is Peter Hearn allowed to buy influence in the Labour Party? | Morning Star, <https://www.morningstaronline.co.uk/article/f/why-is-peter-hearn-allowed-to-buy-influence-in-the-labour-party>
16. 2024 Election Donations - Wes Streeting MP, Ilford North - TheyWorkForYou, https://www.theyworkforyou.com/mp/25320/wes_streeting/ilford_north/election_register
17. Fears Of 'Two-Tier' Shadow Cabinet As Private Donors Bankroll Labour MPs - HuffPost UK, https://www.huffingtonpost.co.uk/entry/labour-two-tier-shadow-cabinet-leadership-keir-starmer_uk_61486c2ae4b0d9b6de993188
18. Register of Interests for Wes Streeting - MPs and Lords - UK Parliament, <https://members.parliament.uk/member/4504/registeredinterests>
19. Health secretary keeps taking donations linked to private health | Good Law Project, <https://goodlawproject.org/health-secretary-keeps-taking-donations-linked-to-private-health/>
20. Wes Streeting could be Britain's next PM — Here are the lobbyists ..., <https://macemagazine.com/wes-streeting-could-be-britains-next-pm-here-are-the-lobbyists-who-come-with-him/>
21. Wes Streeting's links to private health and tech companies under fire in wake of Mandelson texts | The BMJ, <https://www.bmj.com/content/392/bmj.s307>
22. Wes Streeting Net Worth 2026 How Rich Is Labour's Most Talked About Health Secretary?, <https://thebelleisle.co.uk/wes-streeting-net-worth-2026-how-rich-is-labours-most-talked-about-he>

alth-secretary/ 23. Call for Streeting to release messages with private health donors - Doctors' Association UK, <https://dauk.org/call-for-streeting-to-release-messages-with-private-health-donors/> 24. Wes Streeting - Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wes_Streeting 25. Matthew Hood appointed as senior adviser to Secretary of State - GOV.UK, <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/matthew-hood-appointed-as-senior-adviser-to-secretary-of-state> 26. Wes Streeting has gone – what does it mean for the NHS and social care?, <https://www.kingsfund.org.uk/insight-and-analysis/blogs/wes-streeting-has-gone> 27. Revealed: Labour ministers took donations from Big Pharma and US healthcare lobbyists – EveryDoctor's campaign against privatisation of the NHS, <https://privatisation.everydoctor.org.uk/revealed-labour-ministers-took-donations-from-big-pharm-a-and-us-healthcare-lobbyists/> 28. Labour suspends candidate over Gambling Commission investigation - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/article/2024/jun/25/labour-suspends-candidate-over-gambling-commission-investigation> 29. Kevin Craig - PLMR, <https://plmr.co.uk/team-members/kevin-craig/> 30. Kevin Craig - Business, Politics, Philanthropy, Communications, <https://www.kevincraig.co.uk/> 31. General election: Labour and Tory donors 'bought' selection in Central Suffolk and North Ipswich - openDemocracy, <https://www.opendemocracy.net/en/central-suffolk-north-ipswich-labour-conservative-donors-selected-kevin-craig-patrick-spencer/> 32. The lobbyist connecting Labour's top team with arms firms and energy bosses - openDemocracy, <https://www.opendemocracy.net/the-lobbyist-connecting-labours-top/> 33. Labour candidate's PR firm lobbied against plan for VAT for private schools - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/article/2024/jun/15/labour-candidates-pr-firm-lobbied-against-plan-for-vat-for-private-schools> 34. 2024 United Kingdom general election betting scandal - Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2024_United_Kingdom_general_election_betting_scandal 35. Suspended Labour candidate 'deeply regrets' betting he would lose election | ITV News, <https://www.itv.com/news/2024-06-25/labour-suspend-candidate-after-gambling-watchdog-launch-investigation> 36. Key Moments Of The 2024 General Election Campaign - Politics Home, <https://www.politicshome.com/news/article/key-moments-general-election-campaign> 37. Labour Tribes Mapped: Latest version of PLMR and LabourList's guide to PLP, <https://labourlist.org/2025/11/labour-tribes-mapped-update-plmr-labourlist/> 38. Andy Burnham: 'The real me comes out when I'm angry' - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2020/nov/14/andy-burnham-the-real-me-comes-out-when-im-angry> 39. Careful Andy Burnham, sniping at Westminster won't work - UnHerd, <https://unherd.com/newsroom/careful-andy-burnham-sniping-at-westminster-wont-work/> 40. Can Andy Burnham, Labour's charismatic chameleon, reinvent himself again?, <https://www.ft.com/content/9dd44b54-2271-4687-a146-064f35fe9936?syn-25a6b1a6=1> 41. Politics at a Glance with the Director of GMCA Mayor's Office | Careers Inspiration and Advice | GMACS, <https://gmacs.co.uk/blog/politics-at-a-glance-with-the-director-of-gmca-mayors-office/> 42. Andy Burnham - Powerbase.info, https://powerbase.info/index.php/Andy_Burnham 43. Andy Burnham's authentic self - by Joshi Herrmann - The Mill, <https://manchestermill.co.uk/andy-burnham-authentic-self/> 44. What do Wes Streeting's constituents think of him?, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MYEvuLPdu7M> 45. Labour's Andy Burnham Says Just '50 People Run the UK' as Mayor Hits Out at Westminster and Sunak's Scrappage of HS2 - Byline Times, <https://bylinetimes.com/2024/01/10/labours-andy-burnham-says-just-50-people-run-the-uk-as-m>

ayor-hits-out-at-westminster-and-sunaks-scrappage-of-hs2/ 46. Labour's "playground bullies" expel Neal Lawson - Labour Hub, <https://labourhub.org.uk/2023/06/30/labours-playground-bullies-expel-neal-lawson/> 47. Compass (think tank) - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Compass_\(think_tank\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Compass_(think_tank)) 48. Compass' Neal Lawson claims 17-month probe found him 'not guilty' over tweet - LabourList, <https://labourlist.org/2024/11/neal-lawson-compass-suspension-probe-tweet/> 49. Andy Burnham will push to become PM before Labour conference, allies say - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2026/may/15/andy-burnham-pm-labour-autumn-conference> 50. Lessons from Down Under - Compass, <https://www.compassonline.org.uk/lessons-from-down-under/> 51. After 44 years as a Labour member, I spent 18 months facing expulsion. This is what the party got wrong | Neal Lawson | The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2024/nov/21/labour-member-party-punish-control> 52. Mainstream (political organisation) - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mainstream_\(political_organisation\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mainstream_(political_organisation)) 53. About - Mainstream Labour, <https://www.mainstreamlabour.org/about> 54. Labour Mainstream: An Early Assessment, <https://www.independentlabour.org.uk/2025/11/20/labour-mainstream-an-early-assessment/> 55. Labour insiders form new centre-left network in bid to change party's direction, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2025/sep/07/labour-insiders-form-new-centre-left-network-in-bid-to-change-partys-direction> 56. Mainstream: Labour's last chance? - North East Bylines, <https://northeastbylines.co.uk/news/politics/mainstream-labours-last-chance/> 57. Labour's NEC opens door for Burnham to return to Westminster via Makerfield byelection – as it happened, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/live/2026/may/15/prime-minister-keir-starmer-leadership-contest-wes-streeting-andy-burnham-angela-rayner-latest-news-updates> 58. Who is Josh Simons, the Labour MP who quit for Andy Burnham ..., <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2026/may/14/who-is-josh-simons-labour-mp-andy-burnham> 59. 'Labour Together broke the law' - by Peter Geoghegan - Democracy for Sale, <https://democracyforsale.substack.com/p/labour-together-broke-the-law-dark-money-mcsweeney-simons-starmer> 60. APCO (company) - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/APCO_\(company\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/APCO_(company)) 61. Labour Together - Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Labour_Together 62. Who Is 'Starmtrooper' Josh Simons? - Novara Media, <https://novaramedia.com/2024/06/06/who-is-starmtrooper-josh-simons/> 63. Big brains and glittering careers: five fresh Labour MPs to watch - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/article/2024/jul/07/five-new-labour-mps-westminster-economist-soldier> 64. Lobbyist in Labour Together scandal has been investigating Guardian reporter, say reports, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2026/feb/22/lobbyist-apco-report-thinktank-labour-together-guardian-reporter> 65. Labour minister falsely linked journalists to 'pro-Kremlin' network in emails to GCHQ - The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2026/feb/20/labour-minister-falsely-linked-journalists-to-pro-kremlin-network-in-emails-to-gchq> 66. Who is Josh Simons and why has he stepped down? - Manchester Evening News, <https://www.manchestereveningnews.co.uk/news/greater-manchester-news/who-josh-simons-stepped-down-33949587.amp> 67. Schrodinger's premier - InPublishing, <https://www.inpublishing.co.uk/articles/schrodingers-premier-26289> 68. The Labour Together scandal goes right to the heart of No 10 – Starmer has nowhere to hide | Peter Geoghegan | The Guardian, <https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2026/feb/17/labour-together-scandal-keir-starmer->

no-10 69. Starmer facing calls for inquiry into Labour thinktank's investigation ..., <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2026/feb/15/labour-together-thinktank-inquiry-calls-journalists-investigation-keir-starmer> 70. Josh Simons referred to PM's ethics watchdog over Labour Together scandal | Morning Star, <https://morningstaronline.co.uk/article/josh-simons-referred-pms-ethics-watchdog-over-labour-together-scandal> 71. Labour Together PR firm 'tried to destroy evidence' of journalist spy scandal - The National, <https://www.thenational.scot/news/26051974.labour-together-pr-firm-tried-destroy-evidence-spy-scandal/> 72. Labour Together and APCO Worldwide: Cabinet Office Rev - Hansard, <https://hansard.parliament.uk/commons/2026-02-23/debates/5A26759F-4847-4972-8383-B3FC679B9AB/LabourTogetherAndAPCOWorldwideCabinetOfficeReview> 73. Josh Simons To Step Down As MP To Pave Way For Andy Burnham, <https://www.politicshome.com/news/article/josh-simons-step-mp-pave-way-andy-burnham> 74. How Labour Together is falling apart - Vashti Media, <https://www.vashtimedia.com/labour-together-falling-apart/> 75. Global Counsel, lobbying firm set up by Mandelson, went bust owing ..., <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/live/2026/apr/23/keir-starmer-peter-mandelson-vetting-cat-ally-robby-robby-vet-uk-politics-latest-news-updates> 76. We tracked the Mandelson vetting scandal, here's what we found, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_09lyCm_GMg 77. Andy Burnham returns: I will take my fight 'as high as I can go' | ITV News, <https://www.itv.com/news/2026-05-16/andy-burnham-returns-i-will-take-my-fight-as-high-as-i-can-go> 78. It's official: Wes Streeting of the Labour Party wants to be Britain's next prime minister, <https://www.clickondetroit.com/news/2026/05/17/its-official-wes-streeting-of-the-labour-party-wants-to-be-britains-next-prime-minister/> 79. Lord Mandelson - Hansard - UK Parliament, <https://hansard.parliament.uk/commons/2026-02-04/debates/79A0500C-FC08-4AEB-9D2D-3C4540C756C9/LordMandelson> 80. UK health minister Wes Streeting resigns, says 'lost confidence in PM Keir Starmer's leadership', <https://www.hindustantimes.com/world-news/uk-health-minister-wes-streeting-resigns-says-lost-confidence-in-pm-keir-starmer-s-leadership-101778760610021.html> 81. UK's Wes Streeting backs Andy Burnham for Makerfield by-election, <https://www.morningstar.com/news/alliance-news/1778849264517724800/uks-wes-streeting-backs-andy-burnham-for-makerfield-by-election> 82. The Emerging Labour Leadership Camps And Their Visions For The Country, <https://www.politicshome.com/news/article/labour-leadership-contender-camps-visions-for-country> 83. Josh Simons to stand down as MP to allow Burnham return to Parliament - LabourList, <https://labourlist.org/2026/05/josh-simons-resigns-andy-burnham-makerfield-by-election/?amp> 84. Michael Gove and Wes Streeting: Reformers Built for Power, But Not Quite for Leadership? - PLMR, <https://plmr.co.uk/2026/05/michael-gove-and-wes-streeting-reformers-built-for-power-but-not-quite-for-leadership/> 85. UK borrowing costs hit 28-year-high; City braces for Burnham challenge, <https://global.morningstar.com/en-gb/news/alliance-news/1778849471637730900/uk-borrowing-costs-hit-28-year-high-city-braces-for-burnham-challenge>